Distracted

By Lisa Loomer

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! See note from the author about "Casting" below. This may be considered an exception for some tournaments. Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

NOTE: *from the Author: The actors can play multiple roles. Feel free to use accents for the various doctors the actors portray.*

SUGGESTED ROLES: Actor: Jesse, Dad, Dr. Zavala, Dr. Jinks
Actress: Mama, Mrs. Holly

MAMA: *(calls offstage; optimistic)* Morning, Jess! Are you dressed? *(No answer)* Are you getting dressed, baby?

JESSE: I'm dressed!

MAMA: Get dressed, Jesse- *(to audience)* He's nine. *(We continue to hear Jesse's voice offstage for the remainder of this cutting – Jesse never is seen . . only heard)*

JESSE: Where the hell are my rocket balloons?

MAMA: *(embarrassed)* Don't say hell, Jess. And they're your toys, babe, you find 'em. What do you want for breakfast?

JESSE: Candy.

MAMA: *(laughs - to audience)* Sure, I'd love a couple of Almond Joys myself! *(calls)* Well, you can't, 'cause it's not good for you. *(beat)* So what do you want?

JESSE: *(shouts)* Poached eggs! Whatever!

MAMA: *(to audience)* And when they're done, he changes his mind. He gets Coca Crispies, and after he has filled it too high with milk, and spilled it on the floor, he finds a rocket balloon, and, instead of eating, he gets . . . distracted.

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INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS: *What's wrong with nine-year-old Jesse? He can't sit still, he curses, he raps, and you can't get him into-or out of-pajamas.*
ACTOR: *His teacher thinks it's Attention Deficit Disorder.*
ACTRESS: *Dad says, "He's just a boy!" And Mama's on a quest for answers.*
ACTOR: *Is Jesse dysfunctional, or just different?*
ACTRESS: *Don't we all have ADD, to some degree?*
ACTOR: *It seems that everyone today is*
TOGETHER: *Distracted by Lisa Loomer*

JESSE: I gotta find the pump for the rocket balloons!

MAMA: We're not setting off rocket balloons!

JESSE: *(explodes)* I don't want to set them off! I just want to find the fucking pump! *(A pause. Mama smiles at the audience, embarrassed by the word.)*

MAMA: All right, find it. And then get dressed and eat-or eat and get dressed, whatever. *(to audience)* I know. I should have given one simple command. I should have given a "time out" for the [F-word]. [But] I've just read a book called THE EXPLOSIVE CHILD which says you should pick your battles. You should have an A basket for issues of safety, a C basket for issues that are not important right now, and a B basket for the negotiables. . . . He's a little . . . anxious. At least that's what the psychologist who observed him last week at school thought. *(Dr. Zavala enters. - Note that Dr. Zavala might be played by a male. In that case, all references to "her" become "he" or "him")*

DR. ZAVALA: Well, let's see . . . I spent about three hours observing him at school . . . I watched him in class, in P.E . . . at lunch . . . I also spoke with his teacher - And from what I observed . . . He is a pretty anxious child. And he seems to try to compensate for the anxiety by being funny-

MAMA: *(pleased}* Really? He was funny?

DR. ZAVALA: Well-sometimes. He uses physical humor quite a lot, falling off a chair, falling off his desk, running into a wall in an effort to engage the other children-

MAMA: *(hopeful)* Did they laugh?

DR. ZAVALA: Well-sometimes. But he really can't rely on this as a way to connect to other kids.

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And often, he'd just go off on his own. *(looks at notes; sadly)* He ate his lunch alone. I'm sorry. And, like his teacher told you at your Conference, he does seem to be easily . . . distracted. *(actor exits scene and actress plays both Mama and Mrs. Holly for the next section – DI style)*

MAMA: *(to audience)* Our parent-teacher conference was a month ago. Which is what clued us in there was a problem,

MRS. HOLLY: Well, one of the problems is that he doesn't want to do the work. He says he hates reading, he hates writing, and he hates math. You might want to get him tested for Attention Deficit Disorder-

MAMA: Are you saying our child has ADD!?

MRS. HOLLY: No- *(to audience)* I'm not allowed to say that. *(to Mama)* I'm just saying that I've been teaching for twenty-two years and I think testing for ADD might be a good idea. He cannot – **cannot** - stay on task. You know, Thomas Edison Elementary has the best test scores in the city-

MAMA But Thomas Edison never would have made it through Thomas Edison-because Thomas Edison had ADD! You know, some amazing people have had ADD. Mozart had it, Einstein . . . Tom Sawyer, Huck Finn . . .

MRS. HOLLY: Mrs. Cara. A child with ADD is going to have trouble paying attention in **any** educational setting. How's he going to get through the next ten years?

MAMA: *(after a beat)* I don't know, Mrs. Holly. . . . Great! *(sighs; to audience)* Nine weeks from [then]. I head for my weekly appointment with Dr. Zavala. *(Dr. Zavala enters scene)*

DR. ZAVALA: So how are things going?

MAMA: Well, I guess you could say I had a little trouble with the basket system this morning in terms of the word "fucking."

DR. ZAVALA: *(Dr. Zavala has a lot of enthusiasm for the basket system.)* I understand. Let's see if I can help. Now, kicking, for example, is a matter of safety and definitely goes in the A basket. With the [F-word] . . . I'd say B or C basket, depending on the family. [The F-word] doesn't literally hurt anyone, but could get him suspended from school... And if you're

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churchgoers, [the F-wrd] could be a problem for all of you. So I'd say we leave it for the C basket-for the moment. And, in the meantime, I'm going to give you the name and number of an excellent psychiatrist.

MAMA: A psychiatrist!? Wait a minute. Psychiatrists prescribe drugs! I'm not putting my child on drugs. In no universe am I putting my child on drugs. *(Dr. Zavala leaves)* On the way home, I stop at Border's and pick up a few books on ADD.

***********New Scene – Night. Mama is reading in her living room. **********

JESSE: *(exuberantly insistent – off stage)* I'm watching "Fast And Furious!"

MAMA: *(reading)* No you are not.

JESSE: Well, I'm having a snack.

MAMA: As soon as you're in your pajamas. Are you in your pajamas?

JESSE: *(screaming)* Why do I always have to get into my stupid pajamas? I'm just going to get out of them again! It's so stupid! It's such a waste of time!

MAMA: Do it or no snack! *(to audience)* He gets his pajamas on after doing a little dance in his underwear pretending to be a rapper . . . and checking *off* the date on his calendar and counting the days till Fourth of July . . . and playing earthquake . . .

DAD: *(Dad enters.)* Well, he is in bed. And it's only ten thirteen. What're all those books?

MAMA: Oh, I'm just doing a little reading on ADD.

DAD: Jesse doesn't have ADD. He's just a boy. Can't a boy be a boy anymore? I was the same when I was a kid. Worse. All the boys in my neighborhood were pretty wild. They stole. They tortured animals. They're cops and lawyers and businessmen now.

MAMA: Can I just read you a check list of symptoms of ADD? Short attention span. Distractibility. Impulsivity. Other symptoms include . . . Disorganized thinking, poor judgment, risk taking and conflict seeking. *(closes book)*

DAD: Impulsivity, short attention span, risk taking, getting distracted? Those are symptoms-of childhood! Is childhood a disorder now?

MAMA: Well . . . At least we've got a diagnosis . . . *(to audience)* I call Dr. Zavala. *(Actor morphs into Dr. Zavala - Mama sighs)*

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DR. ZAVALA: Have you thought about calling a psychiatrist?

MAMA: Look, I know what a psychiatrist does-a psychiatrist prescribes drugs! For a nine year old child!

DR. ZAVALA: I understand. I think you're right to try everything else first, every conceivable good option.

MAMA: Sorry. So what other conceivable good option can we try?

DR. ZAVALA: Well, a good behavior modification program is essential with or without medication.

MAMA: Okay. Let's do it.

DR. ZAVALA: Terrific. First, you're going to buy a set of poker chips. (*Dr. Zavala delineates the following with great enthusiasm.)* Then. You're going to make a chart of all the behaviors you want to see from Jesse, and you'll decide how many points each is worth. For instance: If he gets into his pajamas on the first request-you'll give him five poker chips. If he does not get into pajamas . . . you'll take away five poker chips as a consequence. Next, you're going to ask his teacher to make a list of behaviors **she** wants to see in class. Then, you're going to make two more charts. One for Daily Rewards. And one for Future Rewards. Daily Rewards might be watching TV, having dessert, riding his bike . . . And you'll decide how many poker chips each of these will cost. Then, each day, you'll tally up the chips he's earned at home and at school . . . He has to spend the chips for Daily Rewards **that** day.

MAMA: Shouldn't there be some perks that just come with childhood?

DR. ZAVALA: Unfortunately, it's not easy to motivate the ADHD child to comply, and that's causing enormous difficulties . . . Shall we make an appointment for next week to see how it's going?

MAMA: Sure. *(to audience)* Why even *pretend a week's gone by*? *(They don't)*

DR. ZAVALA *(brightly)* So how's it going?

MAMA: Well, my husband didn't think it was fair that Jesse had to earn points to ride his bike because exercise is necessary for a child. He also felt Jesse should get some warnings before losing points . . . There was also a little problem with Jesse's teacher.

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MRS. HOLLY: *(resentful)* He forgets to give me the Daily Rewards Sheet so I can fill it out and give him his chips. And when he remembers, he forgets to bring it home.

DR. ZAVALA: Well, I can certainly understand your frustration

MAMA: *(to audience)* But if he could remember the Daily Rewards Sheet, he wouldn't need the Daily Rewards Sheet because he wouldn't have ADD!

MRS. HOLLY: I heard that! You know the other mothers are whispering about you.

DR. ZAVALA: Look. I think we're all here because we care. About Jesse. So how about this. Could you ask him for the Daily Rewards Sheet and fill it out and put it in his book bag?

MRS. HOLLY: If I didn't have twenty-seven other children in my class, I could! And I could follow him into the bathroom so he doesn't get into wet paper towel fights! And while I'm there, maybe even help him wipe his little-

MAMA: *(to audience)* You know she didn't say that. But what she did say was much worse.

MRS. HOLLY: I'm going to recommend he be sent to Special Ed. *(Mrs. Holly exits)*

DR. ZAVALA: *(to Mama)* Clearly we are at a crisis point . . . where Jesse's self-esteem is at stake. So what I am going to say . . . And you know I don't say this lightly . . . But we've tried a number of approaches . . . And, at this point, I'd be terribly negligent if I did **not** say

MAMA: *(to audience)* Is there some way to not have to hear this!?

DR. ZAVALA: Ritalin.

MAMA: What kind of mother drugs a nine-year-old!?

DR. ZAVALA: One who leaves no stone unturned when she's trying to help her child. *(pause.) W*hen Ritalin works, it can seem like a miracle. *(Dr. Zavala morphs into Dr. Jinks)*

DR. JINKS: Dr. David Jinks . . . Giving a child with ADHD Ritalin is like giving a child with diabetes insulin. Or giving a child with astigmatism glasses. The world comes into focus for the first time. Before Ritalin, you can give a child the same instruction day in, day out, and no matter how clear you are, how strict you are, what a good parent you are . . . it simply may not stick. With Ritalin, he simply cannot **not** pay attention.

MAMA: Why? What does it do?

DR. JINKS: It's a stimulant. Which the ADD brain needs. Are you with me? Am I going too fast?

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MAMA: Not at all. *(He begins to speak louder or more insistently . . . or so it seems to her.)*

DR. JINKS: ADD is a life span disorder. Thirty-five percent of kids with ADD never finish high school. Forty-five percent of males with ADD are arrested for a felony before the age of sixteen, and fifty to seventy-five percent of the prison population has some form of ADD. The divorce rate for people with ADD is two times the average, they're five times as likely to get into car accidents- And people with untreated ADD are three times more likely to abuse drugs.

MAMA: But isn't Ritalin a Class 2 Restricted drug for its potential for addiction and abuse? Isn't it speed?

DR. JINKS: As I said, it is a stimulant.

MAMA: And [this] drug - sorry, medication - can cure ADD?

DR. JINKS: The patient is able to concentrate while the drug is active in the system.

MAMA: And when it wears off?

DR. JINKS: He is himself again.

MAMA: Oh terrific. So Ritalin doesn't cure? You can take it for the rest of your life and it doesn't cure a thing? What about side effects?

DR. JINKS: The most common are loss of appetite, delayed growth, and insomnia, but we can always add another drug like Clonidine to help the insomnia. Some children develop tics, but we can add a little Tenex to control that. *(Mama nods as Dr. Jinks morphs into Dad)*

*****Scene change*****

DAD: So you want to put Jesse on drugs.

MAMA: *(quietly)* No. Just . . . trying to keep an open mind.

DAD *(keeping a lid on)* Cause, see, where I come from, "drugs" is kind of a bad word. *(ironic but deadly)* I also have a problem with the idea of somebody giving my son drugs to keep him nice and quiet. Maybe I don't think nice and quiet is such a good thing. . . . But, just like you, I'm trying to keep an open mind. So . . . what are you thinking?

MAMA: I'm thinking he has another ten years in school. Some school. He has to show up someplace between eight and three o'clock. For the next ten years.

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DAD: School's a bore! Especially for a kid like Jesse who can't stand to sit there putting commas in sentences that don't mean anything to him or anybody else. "Who was the twenty-sixth president?" "Attention Deficit?" Teach them something worth paying attention to!

MAMA: I agree. But even if we could afford private school - the private schools don't want him. I mean, they say they want "diversity," but that just means they want different colored kids who know how to sit still and be quiet. They don't want different kinds of minds!

DAD: Well, too bad, they got 'em. Kids' minds **are** different now. Anything they're asked to memorize, they can get on the computer faster-so what do they need a bunch of meaningless facts stored in their heads for? So they can get a good grade on a test? "No Child Left Behind?" The whole country's being left behind!

MAMA: I know, honey, but **our** child is the one being "recommended" for Special Ed!

DAD: Special Ed? Special Ed is like preschool for jail!

MAMA: Well, either the school system has to change. Or Jesse does. *(with great difficulty)* What's worse? Giving a child a drug? Or having him go to school day after day, year after year, hearing his name called out like a curse, seeing the smiles on teachers' faces turn to frowns. Do you think he's falling *off* desks to make people laugh because he's having a good time?

DAD: So you would drug our child to fit into a school system that is not only outdated but unkind? I love that child! That's-my boy! *(breaks into tears)* I love- *(crying)* I don't know what to do . . . I just want him to be . . . a happy kid . . .

MAMA: I know. I know. So do I . . . *(Dad exits – Mama to audience)* The next week, I . . . try Ritalin in the form of a drug called Concerta which is designed to last ten to twelve hours. The first week, Jesse doesn't eat lunch, picks at dinner, and doesn't fall asleep till one a.m. At eight p.m., when the drug starts to wear off, I ask him to get into his pajamas.

JESSE: *(bursts into tears)* Leave me alone! Just leave me alone! Why are you always bothering me? Why can't you leave me alone! I'm trying to be good! I'm trying to be good so we can be a happy family!

MAMA: *(to audience)* Dr. Jinks increases the dosage. Twice. And soon, by seven-thirty p.m.,

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Jesse's in his pajamas. By seven-thirty a.m., he's dressed. Even on Saturday. *(calls to Jesse)* Jesse? *(beat)* Jesse?

JESSE: Yeah? *(Jesse sounds rather like . . . a zombie.)*

MAMA: What are you doing, sweetie?

JESSE: *(flatly)* Watching TV.

MAMA: Do you want to do a watercolor with me? *(beat)* Do you want to make hors d'oeuvres? *(beat)* Jess? *(Dad crosses through the living room.) (Mama to Dad)* He's still not eating. He's pretty much been sitting there all weekend-

DAD: Nice and quiet? *(Mama nods. He exits. Mama heads toward Jesse's room.*

MAMA: Jesse? It's time for your pill, Jess.

JESSE: *(enraged)* I hate it, Mom! I hate it! It makes me feel like I've got bugs inside!

MAMA: Well, the doctor says you have to give it a little time. Then you'll feel fine.

JESSE: I hate it! I hate you!

MAMA: *(to audience)* He begins to pant. I tell him to take a deep breath, but he can't. His breathing gets faster and faster. He flings the towels in the linen closet on the floor - and then he does something which scares the shit out of me, breaks my heart, and makes me know I am unfit to have a child. *(beat)* He hides. In the linen closet.

DAD: *(Dad enters and is dead calm)* If you continue to give my son drugs, I will divorce you, and I will fight for custody. My son is not crazy. He's not a danger to anyone, and he wasn't a danger to himself till you gave him speed. He'll get through school . . . like I did. He'll be the black sheep. The freak. The weirdo. But he'll survive. *(Mama is about to burst into tears. Dad just looks at her and leaves. We hear Jesse crying softly from the closet offstage.)*

MAMA: *(long silence, then . . .repeats with even great difficulty)* What's worse? Giving a child a drug? Or having him go to school day after day, year after year, hearing his name called out like a curse.

JESSE*: (softly off stage in a zombie like voice)* I'm trying to be good! I'm trying to be good so we can be a happy family . . .

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